Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

   It's cooking only. Just planning what you will eat in a day, like rice and beans in the morning, in the evening you eat potatoes, like that.

   Follow up: Where do you do groceries?

   I like to shop at WinCo.

   Follow up: Do you have cooking appliance?

   Yes

   Follow up: DO you know how to use the cooking appliances?

   Yes

   Follow up: What kind of food do you like to buy?

   I like to buy sweet potatoes, chicken and fish

   Follow up: How did you know where to buy groceries? Did your caseworker teach you?

   We used to get busses and trains. The caseworker showed us the stores.

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
   a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

      Most of the time it happens when food stamp is closed. You go to the store and find there's no money in the card.

      Follow up: Does your food stamp get closed a lot or are you talking about when the money for the month is finished?

      When money is finished, you try your best. You see I have 2 children. The $300 that they put in my card cannot be enough.

   b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

      I have children; when food is finished, they help me and do groceries for me. We do not lack food a lot.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?
    i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.
    A lot. Even now they still help me
    Follow up: What do they help you with?
    When I don't have soap, they give me. When kids lack something, they also help them.
    Follow up: Do they also help you with food?
    They usually give me a paper to go to the Bishop store and they give me food.
    Follow up: What kind of food do you get at the bishop store?
    Vegetables like tomatoes, cabbage, carrots and meat like chicken and fruits.
    Follow up: Is the food that they give you enough to help you reach the next time they put money in the card.
    Yes, but I don't go there all the time. I go there when I feel like things are hard.
    ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?
    Give us gardens. We requested them and they heard us
d. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?
    This happens when they have closed food stamp.
e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:
    i. You indicated that you have used Food Pantries program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
    We get oil, tomato sauce and other things.
    Follow up: How did you know about it?
    I cannot fail to know when I work with them. They tell us to go and get food at Sunnyvale.
    ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program?
    They give the food every Saturday, but I don't go there all the time.
    Follow up: Do they also give you vegetables?
    I grow my own vegetables.
    Follow up: When do you go there to get the food
    iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.
    Oil, tomato sauce and other things.
    iv. What % of your foods come from this program?
    Like 20%

v. You indicated that you have used SNAP program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

Caseworkers took us to DWS and helped us to appl for food stamp and Medicaid. We went everywhere with the cards

vi. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

You buy what is possible. $300 cannot buy everything I need. I have a child who is 20 years old who gets sick a lot but it's okay. No problem

vii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

I like to buy rice, oil, and other food we eat.

viii. What % of your foods come from this program?

Like 50%

Follow up: Where do other percentages come from?

My children help me, but I also have garden and I farm many things like vegetables. I always have flour, rice and other things.

ix. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>: Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

I have children. When they close the food stamps, the children help me to call them and they reopen them.

Follow up: DO you know how to appl for them?

No, I don't know. But caseworkers also help me.

Follow up: So, how do you find out when food stamp is closed?

When I have gone to do groceries and then I find that there's no money on the card. It's usually so embarrassing.

Follow up: Do you know how to apply for food stamp on your own?

When I never went to school? I cannot know. I usually go there, and they help me to apply.

Follow up: If there's an interpreter, can you manage to reapply?

No, they help me to apply. They ask me questions and I answer them.

x. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

Things related to food, for us we farm. They give us seeds and we farm for ourselves.

f. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months:

i. You indicated that you have used NSLP program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

The teachers told us about it.

Follow up: Who helped you to apply?

The way things are, when there's no money in food stamp, they tell us that your child is eating free food, yet they don't have food stamp. Then we know immediately that food stamp is closed, and the child is eating other people's food.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

At school, there's no problem there.

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

    There are sweet potatoes, plantains, potatoes. I find everything here.

    Follow up: What's the most important thing about your cultural food?

    It's the nutrients. There's a lot of nutrients.

    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

    From my garden

    c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?
        i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

        We requested them for a garden, and they heard us

    d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

    For food, we sell them. We sell at a market by redwood road and at Sunnyvale market. Like right now, we have put the food in the fridge, and we will go and sell tomorrow.

    e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?
        i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

        Because we are the ones that sell the food there.

    f. Ask those who have used New Roots: Can you describe your experience with the New Roots program (also known as IRC Garden or IRC Farm Program)?
        i. Did this program give you more food to eat? please explain

        I get food and I even sell some and get money to buy soap.

        Follow up: How did you know about it?

        Well, because I never went to school and could not manage to work after my back became an issue. I decided to do farming. But even when used to go work, I still used to do farming. I have been doing farming for the past 15 years.

        Follow up: How did you know about the program?

        We requested IRC. We requested that we are not managing to eat the food here. They heard us and gave us a garden, and we started farming.

        ii. Can you describe the training you received in this program?

        This program of farming helps us a lot. I'm even worried what I will do in snow time. I like to go to the garden.

        Follow up: What do you grow?

We grow lots of vegetables such as tomatoes, different types of egg plans, cucumber, and many other things. We grow so many plants. We grow food from our country and here.

iii. Can you explain whether and how this program has helped you in any ways?

It's like sport and you benefit from it. You buy clothes, and other things. There's nothing else that we need.

Follow up: Why do it you like it so much? Is mostly because it's like sport for you or because you get food from your culture?

I like it a lot. I don't like staying home all day. The farming keeps me busy. When I go to the garden, I'm busy thinking what I will do, like, I need to water this plant, I will plant these seeds for this area, I need to do this for those plants. But when I'm in the house, I start thinking of many things. Like things that happened a long time ago.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

   I don't know. Maybe they help themselves or they like to stay in the house.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

   The way I see it, I think everyone can get a garden. Even if you have a job, you can still have a garden and farm for yourself like vegetables.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

   I don't know what else IRC can do. There's nothing that IRC did not do. It all depends on somebody's heart.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   What I can add is; IRC helped us a lot and even now, they are still helping us. There are some people that don't do farming. But for us, we do it. IRC gave us gardens. You can see, there's nothing that they haven't done.

   Follow up: What percentages of your food come from your garden?

   When I sell and get cash, I use it to buy things like oil.

   Follow up: What's the biggest source of food for you? Is it food stamp or is it from your garden?

It’s from my garden. I mix them all. Like rice, I buy it from the market. But things like vegetables, I get them from the garden.